



Blame Game all Over Again

JAIPUR That terror always targets the innocent was proved yet again when a bomb exploded at the Khwaja Moinuddin Chisti dargah in Ajmer on October 11. Two persons were killed and 17 were injured. The police say the trail of evidence leads to the perpetrators of the Hyderabad blasts. The recovery of a deactivated SIM card from the site, procured under the same fake name as in the case of the Mecca mosque blast in Hyderabad in May, only

confirms the suspicion. The explosion was triggered by a timer in which the mobile phone was used as a time device and not as a remote control. A strong needle of suspicion points towards Syed Salim of Hyderabad who died in the blast. He was an absconder in an earlier passport fraud case in Hyderabad. Police are also looking into the possibility of narcotic smugglers linked with terror groups. Just a few days before the blast, the police

SHAKEN: Blast site had arrested two persons near the dargah and recovered three pistols and three rifles. The two were linked to Nafis Chisti who was caught with narcotics worth Rs 25 crore in Delhi a few years ago.

The police are still baffled about the low intensity of the blast and are wondering if it was aimed at creating a scare or targeting a select few. There is the usual politics too with some wondering why the dargah khadims who were incensed when actor Katrina Kaif visited the dargah in a skirt, have been silent about the attack. Chief Minister Vasundhara Raje put the ball in the Centre's court saying that the security of the dargah was in the hands of a committee appointed by the Centre and the state police could not do much. Union Home Minister Shivraj Patil did a routine inspection and was surprised to know about the Centre's inaction over the state's response.

by Rohit Parihar

Heads or Tails

THIRUVANANTHAPURAM

Mons Joseph, 42, joined the Kerala Cabinet headed by V.S. Achuthanandan last week but considering the cauldron that Kerala politics is, it is not known how long he will last. One thing, however, is certain: his name will be etched forever as the first-ever minister in the country chosen through the toss of



a coin. The new Public Works Minister was thus chosen after two factions in the party put forward their own respective candidates for the post. Favouring one at the cost of the other would have caused yet another split in the party which has already been splintered five times. So the two factions settled for a toss.

Mons is the third nominee from Kerala Congress (J) in the Left Democratic Front Government in the last 16 months. The first, party chief P.J. Joseph had to quit last year after he allegedly misbehaved with a lady fellow traveller on board a flight. His successor T.U. Kuruvila had to resign last month when allegations of his son and daughter being involved in a land scam surfaced. The fun, however, will only begin if Joseph is exonerated by the Chennai Police next month and he stakes claim to his original seat.

by M.G. Radhakrishnan

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